



## BLUE Rs 100 crore

**STARRING** Akshay Kumar, Sanjay Dutt, Zayed Khan

**HYPE** It's a cross between *The Deep* and *Jaws*. There's a treasure, friendship, betrayal, and Lara Dutta in Rina Dhaka bikinis. Shot in the Bahamas and Thailand.

**HOPE** Sanjay Dutt, paid Rs 17 crore for this, in a swimsuit? No, oh no.

**RECESSION INDEX** Still looking for a buyer. The asking price of Rs 120 crore is too high.

## ALLADIN Rs 85 crore

**STARRING** Amitabh Bachchan, Riteish Deshmukh

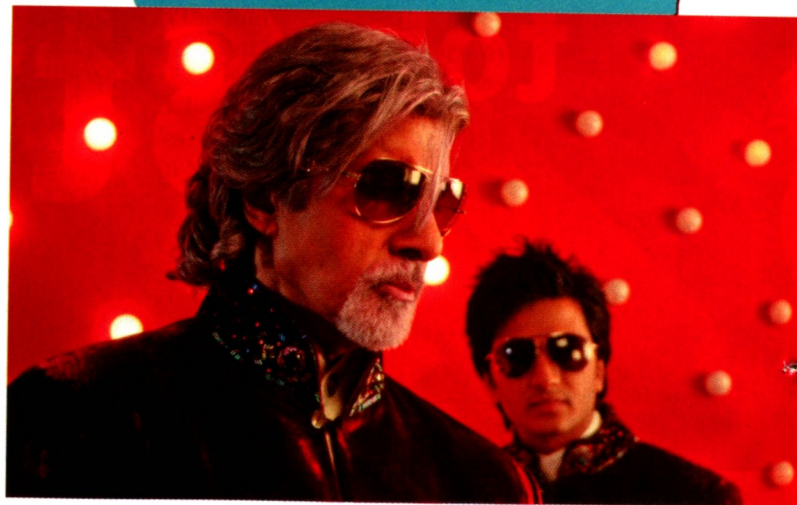
**HYPE** Special effects-laden thriller that children will love with Amitabh as the friendly genie who dispenses dating advice to Riteish, who's called, what else, Alladin.

**HOPE** It's not like *Drona*, Eros's earlier attempt to push the technology buttons. Help.

**STRIKE IMPACT** Release postponed from July.

Soon, though, there will be a problem of plenty, a movie traffic jam, with each production house committed to a certain number of releases. The 750-odd screens that currently seem bereft of products will soon be buzzing with an excess of films. "Won't they eat into each other's business?," asks Sajid Nadiadwala, who is still overcome by getting Stallone's signature on a *Rocky* boxing glove he picked up from the actor's Beverly Hills mansion. He's pushed back on the production of his next film, *Houseful*, a comedy caper set in Las Vegas, starring Akshay Kumar, Katrina Kaif and Arjun Rampal. Akshay, partly at fault for the rise in prices of talent, is also responsible for keeping much of Bollywood afloat. With *Kambakkht Ishq*, *Blue* and *De Dana Dhan* in the bag, he has already shot 60 per cent of Shah's *Action Replay* at ND Studios in Karjat, where he and Aishwarya Rai-Bachchan play time travellers based in the '70s. Not surprisingly Akshay's declared income for the last year was Rs 160 crore which saw him pay a monthly income tax of Rs 5 crore.

Yet there's an all round sigh of relief that is being heard all the way down to the beach houses in Kashid and the weekend homes in Alibagh, purchased at the height of Bollywood's beautiful boom. Producers are hoping that newcomers like Imran Khan, treated to economy class tickets and Dolphin hotels by their producer uncles, do not demand Rs 7 crore per film. Or that character actors such as Vinay Pathak don't dig their heels in on Rs 1 crore to play expensive props. Or that Akshay Kumar doesn't charge a "discounted" price of Rs 33.5 crore a week, as he was doing even after his last bomb, *8X10 Tasveer*, which was made



for Rs 45 crore and grossed just Rs 18 crore.

It's not that deals are not being done. They are. UTV has just purchased two films from Karan Johar, *Wake Up Sid* starring Ranbir Kapoor and Konkona Sen Sharma, and *Qurbaan* with Saif Ali Khan and Kareena Kapoor, both with new directors, for a hefty Rs 68 crore, excluding the music rights. Eros, a big buyer of star-propelled projects, has picked up Saif's own production, the Rs 40-crore *Love Aaj Kal*, for Rs 62 crore. But the reason is clearly less to do with the correct valuation and more to do with relationship building. Others are more realistic. For instance, Indian Films has picked up Neeraj Vora's Rs 12-crore *Shortcut*, starring Akshaye Khanna, for a sensible Rs 17 crore. As Mahesh Bhatt says: "Bollywood cannot afford to make bad, expensive films any more. It has to get real." Umm, not something it does very well. ■